Tablet sticking and picking: investigation pack

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Use this evidence matrix to organize the assessment before choosing a treatment. Follow approved site procedures for equipment isolation, sampling, cleaning and inspection.

What you observe	What to record	What to investigate
Powder on the punch face	Photograph the deposit before cleaning; record affected stations, onset and batch.	Review tooling condition, formulation and process history together. A coating is one possible route, not an automatic answer.
Powder collecting in logos or numbers	Capture a close-up of the engraving and matching tablet defect; identify tool and station.	Review engraving geometry, finish and formulation interaction. Do not assume polishing alone resolves it.
Defect returns after cleaning	Record time or tablets produced until recurrence and cleaning method.	Compare repeat intervals under comparable conditions; distinguish temporary deposit removal from a sustained change.
Only some stations are affected	Map defects to tool IDs and stations; retain photographs and inspection records.	Check for tool-to-tool differences using the approved inspection procedure.
Defects change between batches	Record lot, sampling method, environment and relevant process records.	Review the product/process differences before attributing the problem to tooling.
Visible tool damage or coating loss	Record condition and segregate suspect tooling under site procedures.	Obtain qualified inspection before considering reuse, restoration or a trial.

Keep observations separate from conclusions. Match each photograph to the tool ID, station, corresponding tablet and point in the run. Preserve original files and records.

Investigation handover checklist

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Record	Complete or reference
Press / tooling set / product reference	_____
Observation window and batches sampled	_____
Upper/lower tool IDs and stations	_____
Defect location, onset and recurrence	_____
Photo IDs: context, face, detail, tablet	_____
Cleaning status and inspection records	_____
Proposed change and testable question	_____
Protocol, approver and acceptance criteria	_____
Stop / segregation / escalation criteria	_____
Other changes or comparison limitations	_____
Outcome and follow-up record reference	_____

Photo log: record the date, tool/station ID, orientation, scale reference and before/after cleaning status. Keep confidential records within the approved company system.

Trial: agree the comparison window and measures before implementation. Record product quality as well as stops, minutes and rejects. A favorable cost scenario does not establish suitability for production.

Compare measured outcomes

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Measure	Baseline	Trial outcome
Observed batches	_____	_____
Stops due to sticking/picking	_____	_____
Stopped minutes	_____	_____
Tablets produced / rejected	_____	_____
Stops per batch	_____	_____
Stopped minutes per batch	_____	_____
Rejected / produced fraction	_____	_____
Quality result / approval reference	_____	_____

Fictional example: 20 stops in 10 batches is 2 stops/batch. Twenty stops in 20 batches is 1 stop/batch: a 50% lower rate. Check comparable batch sizes, product and sampling methods before interpreting that difference.

Financial review: separate costs you can stop paying from fixed payroll and recovered capacity. Avoid counting the same loss in rejects, rework and throughput. Record one-time and recurring costs separately.

Quality-system reference: ICH Q10, Pharmaceutical Quality System, section 3.2.3 (change management). Read ICH Q10. Assess proposed changes before implementation and evaluate their outcome afterward.

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